FIFA World Cup 2026 Predictor

Executive Report · Independent ML Forecasting Project · Generated 2026-06-10

> **Executive summary.** This is an independent analytics initiative: a walk-forward Poisson/Dixon-Coles model forecasts tournament outcomes using 150+ years of international results, calibrated against OPTA benchmarks on 2018 (development) and 2022 (confirmation), then rolled forward to 2026. Production forecast (iteration 7) ranks **Spain** as the highest model win probability (10.0%), versus OPTA favourite **Spain** (16.1%).

48	0.739	0.726
TEAMS (2026 SCHEDULE)	BEST 2018 BRIER (ITER 7)	BEST 2022 BRIER (ITER 7)

PARTICIPATING NATIONS — MODEL PREDICTION ORDER

48 teams arranged by group (A–L), in model pick order: 1st, 2nd, Best 3rd, then 4th. Flags via flagcdn.com — not official FIFA branding.

Group A



1ST
South Korea



2ND
Mexico



BEST 3RD
South Africa



4TH
Czechia

Group B



1ST
Switzerland



2ND
Canada



BEST 3RD
Italy



4TH
Qatar

Group C



1ST
Morocco



2ND
Brazil



BEST 3RD
Scotland



4TH
Haiti

Group D



1ST



2ND



BEST 3RD



4TH

Australia	USA	Paraguay	Kosovo

Group E

1ST	2ND	BEST 3RD	4TH
			
Germany	Ivory Coast	Ecuador	Curacao

Group F

1ST	2ND	BEST 3RD	4TH
			
Japan	Netherlands	Tunisia	Sweden

Group G

1ST	2ND	BEST 3RD	4TH
			
New Zealand	Iran	Egypt	Belgium

Group H

1ST	2ND	BEST 3RD	4TH
			
Spain	Uruguay	Saudi Arabia	Cape Verde

Group I

1ST	2ND	BEST 3RD	4TH
			
France	Norway	Senegal	Bolivia

Group J

1ST	2ND	BEST 3RD	4TH
			
Argentina	Algeria	Austria	Jordan

Group K

1ST	2ND	BEST 3RD	4TH
			
Portugal	Colombia	DR Congo	Uzbekistan

Group L

1ST	2ND	BEST 3RD	4TH
			
England	Croatia	Panama	Ghana

METHODOLOGY

- **Data:** Kaggle international results (1872–present), 2026 fixture schedule, OPTA pre-tournament win %.
- **Model:** Attack × opponent defense Poisson goals; 7 iterations (multiplicative → log-linear → weighted decay → Elo anchor → Dixon-Coles τ → opponent difficulty → competition confederation strength).
- **Match weights:** Tier A/B/C = 1.0 / 0.85 / 0.5; 2-year time half-life.
- **Validation:** Walk-forward — tune on 2018 World Cup, confirm on 2022, produce 2026 forecast.
- **Bracket:** 10,000 Monte Carlo simulations (48-team 2026 format).

BRIER SCORE & DIXON-COLES

Brier score. For each World Cup match we predict three probabilities (home win, draw, away win). The Brier score is the mean squared error between those probabilities and the actual result (expressed as a one-hot vector). Lower is better: 0 is perfect; about **0.67** is the benchmark from naively guessing one-third for every outcome. We average over all 64 held-out tournament matches to compare iterations and years. Iteration choice for development uses the lowest 2018 Brier; 2022 is reported as confirmation without re-tuning.

Dixon-Coles. Classical Poisson models assume home and away goals are independent; real football shows extra correlation on low scores (0–0, 1–0, 0–1, 1–1), especially draws. Dixon and Coles (1997) multiply independent Poisson probabilities by a correction factor τ (rho, ρ) on those scorelines. Our pipeline learns team attack and defense rates via Poisson negative log-likelihood (iterations 1–4); **iteration 5** adds the τ term in training and when converting goal rates to win/draw/loss probabilities. World Cup match scoring uses neutral venues (no home advantage). Elo anchoring (iter 4+) shrinks team strengths toward a stable rating so single shock results do not dominate.

BACKTEST — BRIER SCORE (LOWER IS BETTER)

Year	Iter	Brier	Model favourite	Win %	Actual winner
2018	1	1.2031	Costa Rica	25.3%	France
2018	2	0.7858	Brazil	17.1%	France
2018	3	0.7594	Brazil	18.4%	France
2018	4	0.7424	Brazil	16.9%	France
2018	5	0.7465	Brazil	16.5%	France

Year	Iter	Brier	Model favourite	Win %	Actual winner
2018	6	0.7474	Brazil	17.9%	France
2018	7	0.7387	Brazil	16.4%	France
2022	1	1.0913	Portugal	14.1%	Argentina
2022	2	0.7737	Brazil	13.0%	Argentina
2022	3	0.7638	Brazil	21.3%	Argentina
2022	4	0.7363	Brazil	13.1%	Argentina
2022	5	0.7362	Brazil	12.5%	Argentina
2022	6	0.7347	Brazil	13.0%	Argentina
2022	7	0.7262	Brazil	11.7%	Argentina

2026 FORECAST VS OPTA (ITERATION 7)

OPTA rank	Team	OPTA win %	Model win %	Delta
1	**Spain**	16.1%	10.0%	-6.1pp
23	**Japan**	0.8%	7.7%	+6.9pp
4	**Argentina**	10.4%	7.5%	-2.8pp
20	**Morocco**	0.9%	6.8%	+5.8pp
3	**England**	11.2%	6.0%	-5.1pp
2	**France**	13.0%	5.3%	-7.7pp
6	**Brazil**	6.6%	5.2%	-1.5pp
5	**Portugal**	7.0%	5.1%	-1.9pp
7	**Germany**	5.1%	4.1%	-1.0pp
9	**Norway**	3.5%	3.5%	-0.0pp
13	**Colombia**	1.7%	2.9%	+1.2pp
28	**South Korea**	0.5%	2.8%	+2.3pp

GROUP-STAGE OUTLOOK (12 GROUPS → ROUND OF 32)

Model picks for group winner, runner-up, and best third-place qualifier candidate. 48-team format: 24 auto-qualifiers + 8 best third-place teams.

Group	1st	2nd	Best 3rd
A	South Korea	Mexico	South Africa
B	Switzerland	Canada	Italy
C	Morocco	Brazil	Scotland
D	Australia	USA	Paraguay
E	Germany	Ivory Coast	Ecuador
F	Japan	Netherlands	Tunisia
G	New Zealand	Iran	Egypt
H	Spain	Uruguay	Saudi Arabia
I	France	Norway	Senegal
J	Argentina	Algeria	Austria
K	Portugal	Colombia	DR Congo
L	England	Croatia	Panama

KNOCKOUT REACH PROBABILITIES

Monte Carlo estimates of advancing through each knockout round (iteration 7).

Team	P(QF)	P(SF)	P(Final)	P(Win)
Spain	61.2%	41.3%	16.8%	10.5%
Japan	58.0%	37.2%	14.1%	8.1%
Morocco	75.7%	42.9%	13.5%	7.2%
Argentina	53.1%	32.6%	11.7%	6.9%
England	57.3%	34.2%	11.3%	6.2%
Brazil	68.4%	38.2%	10.5%	5.5%

Team	P(QF)	P(SF)	P(Final)	P(Win)
France	54.1%	30.2%	9.7%	5.2%
Portugal	52.6%	29.1%	8.9%	5.0%
Germany	81.9%	27.7%	7.9%	3.9%
Norway	51.2%	26.5%	7.6%	3.6%

KEY FINDINGS & LIMITATIONS

- Elo anchoring (iter 4+) reduces overreaction to single shock results (e.g. Saudi Arabia 2022).
- Dixon-Coles τ (iter 5) polishes draw/low-score calibration; marginal gain on 2022 holdout.
- Model still underperforms naive benchmarks on some iterations — ongoing calibration work.
- No xG, squad value, or FIFA rank features (collinearity with Elo); neutral venues at World Cup.
- Live in-tournament updates require re-running production with an updated results cutoff (not automated).

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